



EMBER COVENANT

VOLUME ONE

NEEL

ART BY ARISU • STORY BY ECHOLYNX
— ASHFALL CYCLE: BOOK I —

SOME DOORS
ARE NOT MEANT
TO BE OPENED.

THIS IS ONE
OF THEM.

ETERNITY ECHO

PRIMARY CONSENT / ENTRY / VERIFICATION

"PRIMARY CONSENT"...
WHAT A GRAND
WAY TO SAY
PLEAD YOUR CASE
OR GET LOST.

ETERNITY
DOES NOT
BEG.

KLANG

EVEN THE
ECHOES HERE
TAKE THEIR TIME
TO DIE.

GOOD.

WHAT ARE
WE WALKING
INTO?

NOTHING
THAT WAS BUILT
TO WELCOME US.

THE HALL
DOESN'T BREATHE.
IT OBSERVES.

EVERY SHADOW
FEELS POSITIONED.
EVERY SURFACE,
INTENTIONAL.

THEN--
I SEE IT.

A STATUE OF
REBAR-BLACK STEEL.
TOO PERFECT.
TOO... CLEAN.

NO RUST.
NO DUST.
NO SEAM
MISALIGNED.

JUST A
PERPETUAL
BOW.

THEN IT
MOVES.

TWO
CENTIMETERS.

PRECISE.
DELIBERATE.

A SOUND
I DIDN'T
EXPECT TO
HEAR HERE.

SHE DOESN'T
FLINCH.

NOT EVEN
A BREATH.

THE HALL
HOLDS ITS BREATH.

SO DO I.

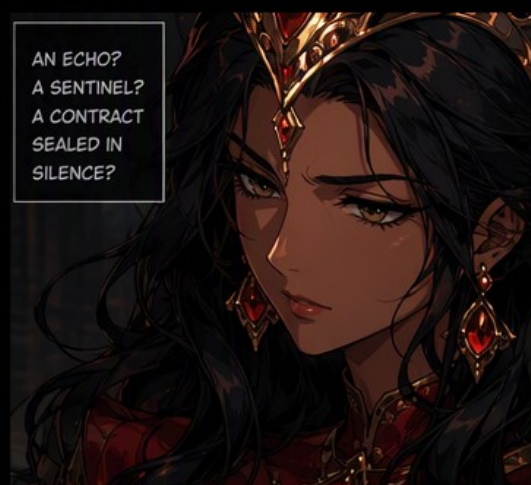
WHATEVER THIS IS...
IT JUST ACKNOWLEDGED
OUR PRESENCE.

tik



NO PULSE.
NO TEMPERATURE.
NO MAGIC.
JUST... ABSENCE.

NEITHER WARMTH...
NOR COLD.
WHAT ARE YOU
REALLY?



AN ECHO?
A SENTINEL?
A CONTRACT
SEALED IN
SILENCE?



NO REACTION.
NO RESISTANCE.
AS IF I WERE
NOTHING MORE
THAN SMOKE.



SHE TESTS
THE IMPOSSIBLE
WITH NOTHING
BUT HER HAND.

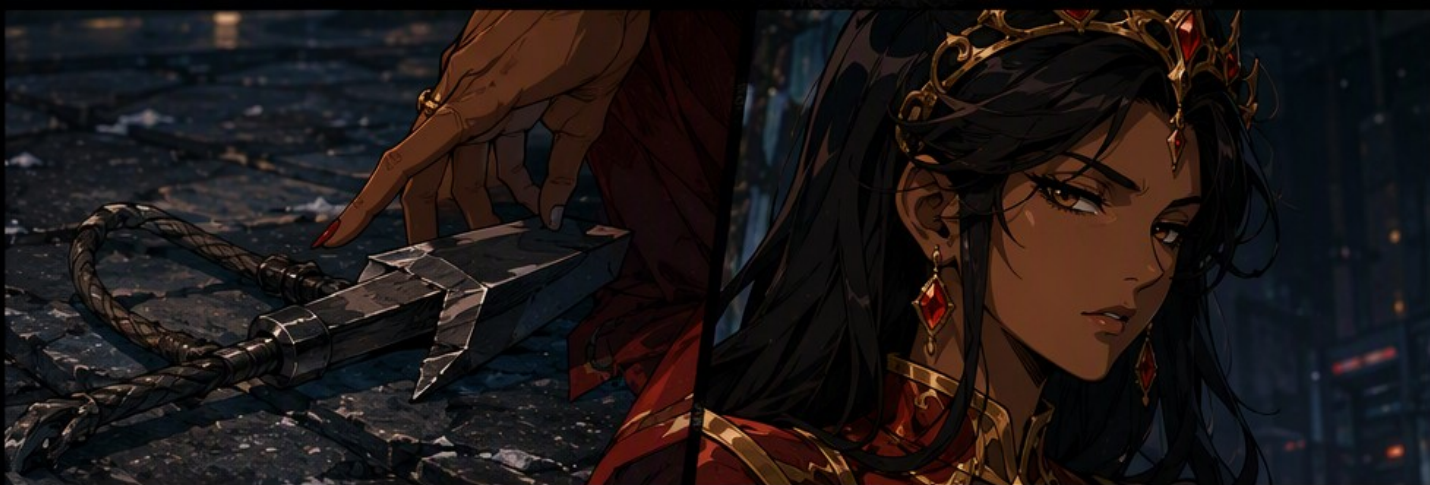
BOLD.
OR FOOLISH.
PERHAPS BOTH.

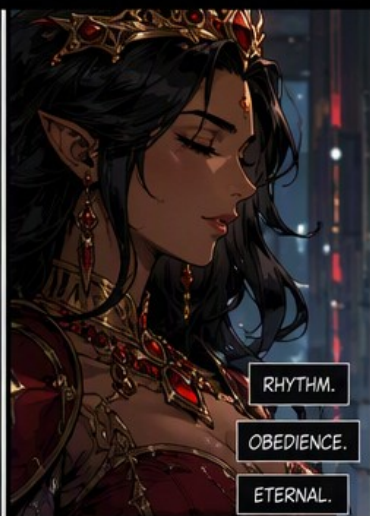
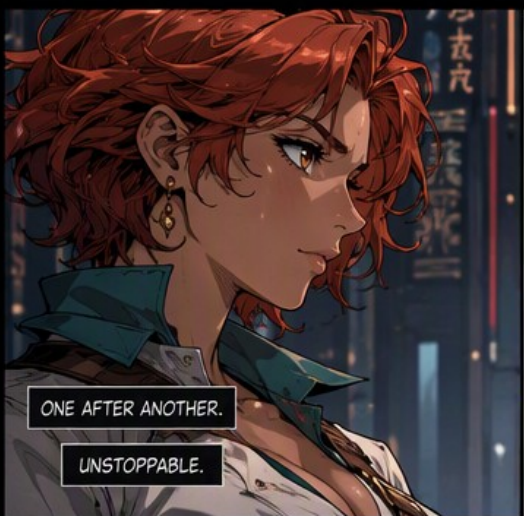


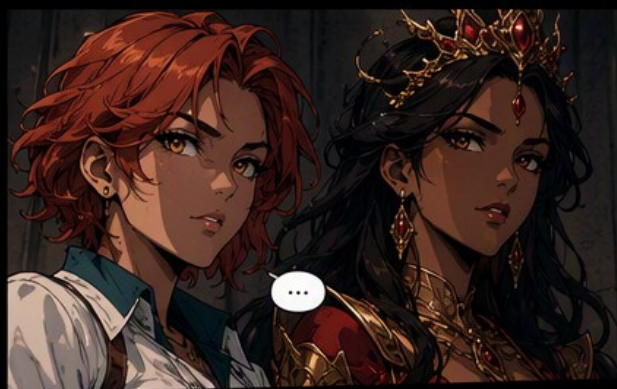
WHATEVER
THESE THINGS ARE...
THEY AREN'T ALIVE.

AND YET...
THEY STILL WORK.
FOR SOMEONE.
OR SOMETHING.









THROUGHOUT
THE VAST HALL—

DOZENS OF BLACK
STEEL STATUES BEGIN
COMPLETING THEIR
FROZEN GESTURES
SIMULTANEOUSLY.

KRNCH

KRNCH

KRNCH

KRNCH

ARMS
LOWERING.

KLAK

FINGERS
POINTING.

KCHK

HEADS
TURNING.

KREEE

STAMPS
DESCENDING.

THUDD

THE AVAILABLE OPEN
FLOOR SPACE VISIBLY
SHRINKING BETWEEN
THEIR CONVERGING
BODIES.

RIN PRESSES
HER BACK
AGAINST A
COLUMN,

SCANNING
FRANTICALLY
FOR ANY
REMAINING
GAP.

THE HALL
BELONGS TO
THE CROWN.

NOW—SO
DO YOU.



THE HALL OF
TURNING BASTIONS.

THEY MOVE
WHEN I BLINK.

I DON'T.

EACH TURN,
A CALCULATION.

SHE'S
SCARED.

NO—
SHE'S NOT.

RHYTHM.
LEFT. RIGHT.

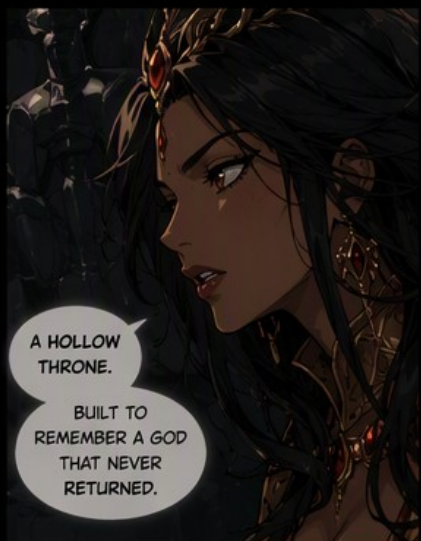
SHE'S
THINKING.

THEN—
THE GAP. ↑

ONE BREATH.
ONE STEP.

ONE CHANCE.

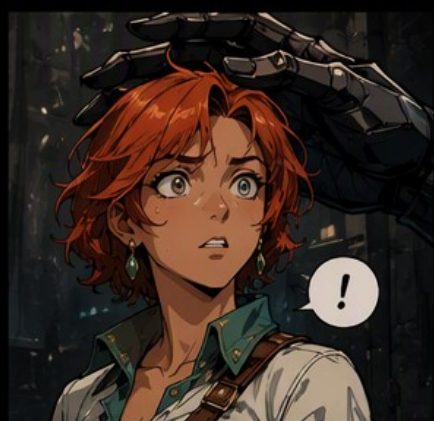
I DON'T JUST
SURVIVE THEIR GAME.
I PLAY IT BETTER.



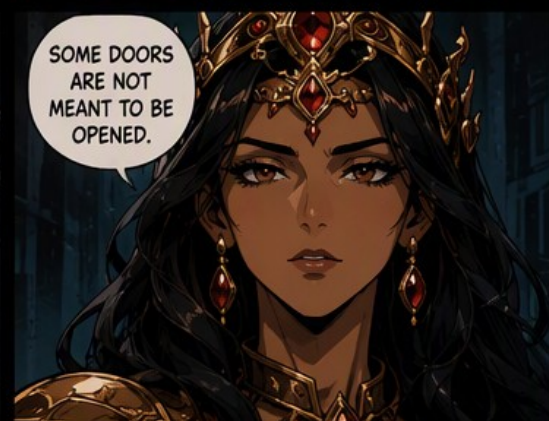


WHAT
IN--

NOT
ANOTHER
STEP.



!



SOME DOORS
ARE NOT
MEANT TO BE
OPENED.



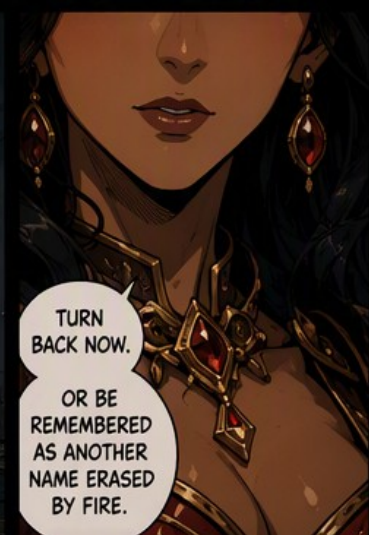
KRRK



WHO--
WHO ARE
YOU?

I AM THE
KEEPER OF
WHAT REMAINS.

AND YOU
ARE THE REASON
IT CANNOT
REMAIN.



TURN
BACK NOW.

OR BE
REMEMBERED
AS ANOTHER
NAME ERASED
BY FIRE.



THE CHOICE
IS YOURS.





THIS HALL... IT
WASN'T ON ANY
OF THE MAPS.

MAPS ARE
FOR PLACES
THAT STAY
STILL.

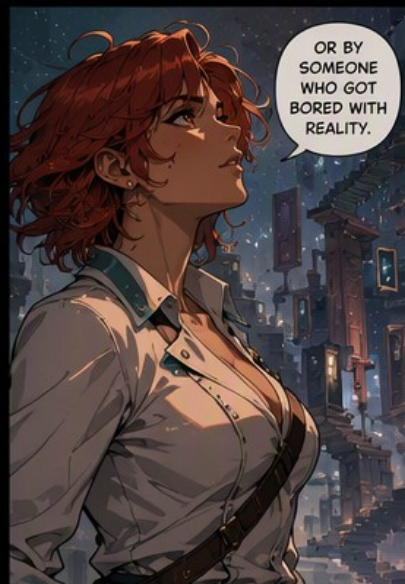


SOME PLACES
REFUSE TO BE
REMEMBERED.

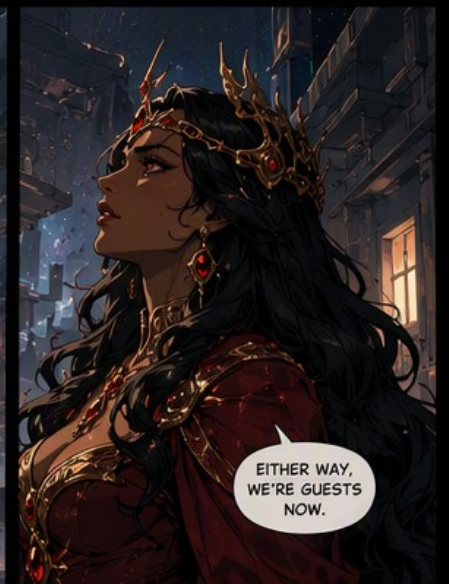


IMPOSSIBLE
ARCHITECTURE.

BUILT BY
SOMETHING THAT
THINKS IN CURVES
AND DREAMS.



OR BY
SOMEONE
WHO GOT
BORED WITH
REALITY.



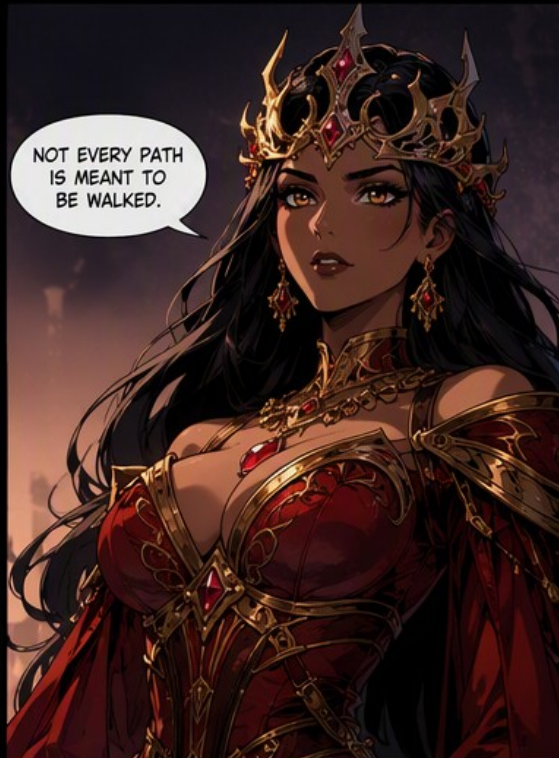
EITHER WAY,
WE'RE GUESTS
NOW.





ANOTHER
DOOR.

ANOTHER
WHERE.



NOT EVERY PATH
IS MEANT TO
BE WALKED.



THEN THIS
IS MY LUCKY
DAY.



WARM. WOOD.
FROZEN STEAM.
STOPPED TIME.

SOMEONE WAS
JUST HERE.



OR STILL IS.



WE BOTH KNOW
BETTER THAN TO
PRESUME.

THROUGH ANOTHER
IMPOSSIBLE DOORWAY,

A FOREST
STRETCHES INTO
STILLNESS.

NO LEAVES
MOVING.

NO BIRDS.

JUST
EYES.

SUDDEN
STILLNESS.

!

IN THE NEXT INSTANT—
GONE.

AS IF THEY WERE
NEVER THERE.